

Motorcycles

Although the American inventor Sylvester Roper built the first motorcycle in 1869, powering it by steam, the motorcycle's story really took off in 1885 with Daimler and Maybach's motorcycle. This vehicle had a petrol engine to power the rear wheel via a moving belt. Motorcycles have come far since then, but most still have a gasoline engine and a drive belt or chain.

First motorcycle

- **What?** Daimler Reitwagen
- **Who?** Gottlieb Daimler and Wilhelm Maybach
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1885

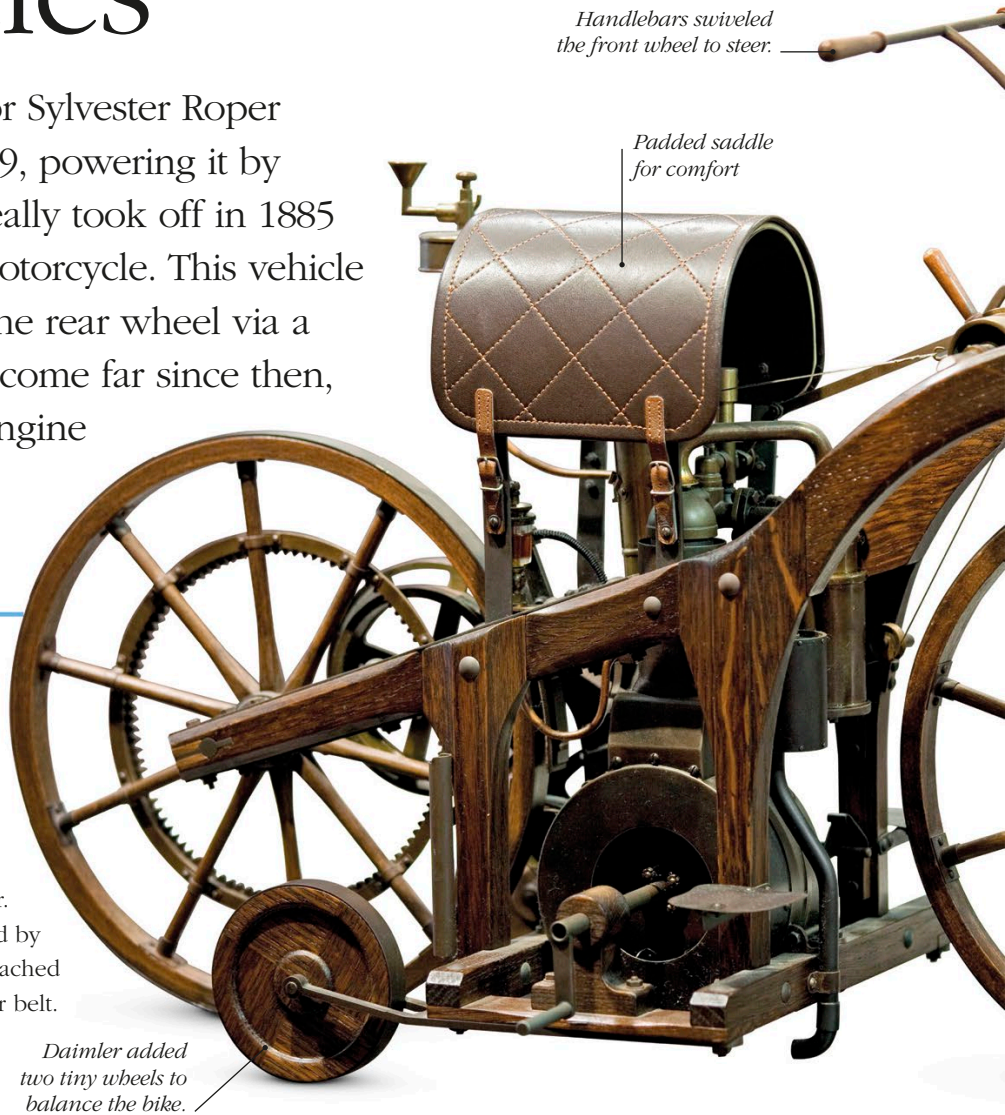
In 1885, the German engineer Gottlieb Daimler and German designer Wilhelm Maybach pioneered the Reitwagen (riding wagon)—a motorcycle that was a test for the first gasoline-engined, four-wheeled car built the following year. They took the basic idea of the bicycle introduced by the British inventor J. K. Starley (see p.84) and attached an engine to power the rear wheel using a leather belt.



First production motorcycle

- **What?** Hildebrand & Wolfmüller Motorrad
- **Who?** Heinrich and Wilhelm Hildebrand, and Alois Wolfmüller
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1894

In 1894, the German Hildebrand brothers teamed up with the German engineer Wolfmüller to create the first production bike. It was the first to be called a motorcycle, and more than 2,000 of them were made between 1894 and 1897.



First bike with telescopic forks

- **What?** BMW R12
- **Who?** BMW
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1935

The BMW R12 was the first bike with telescopic forks, which connect a bike's front wheel and axle to its frame.

The telescopic forks are crucial to motorcycle handling and safety, ensuring the front wheel stays on the ground. While earlier bikes had springs, a fluid-filled telescopic fork in the BMW R12 helped to reduce bouncing.

